THE ART OF REBELLION

When Akbar had directed Salim to proceed to Mewar at the time of the imperial campaigns in the Deccan, his eldest son did not do as he was ordered. He remained instead at Ajmer where ‘from self-indulgence, wine drinking and bad company’ he prevaricated and contemplated his future course of action. The prince was now in his thirties and was beginning to slide away from his youthful good looks. As he gave in to all kinds of indulgences, in food, in wine, and in opium, his square chin would sag into jowly folds, and his gorgeously patterned silk robes would stretch alarmingly over his increasing girth. His body wasn’t the only thing about him that had languished, so had his certitude of becoming Padshah. Most worrying was the fact that his growing sons were being openly favoured by Akbar. The teenaged Khusrau, now a high mansab of 10,000, was further bolstered by the support of the powerful courtiers Mirza Aziz Koka and Raja Man Singh, through ties of marriage and blood.* With Akbar showing no signs of slowing down, Salim must have despaired of ever ruling Hindustan.

Munis Faruqui has pointed out that Ajmer, right in the centre of the Mughal Empire, was an important city geographically, straddling major trade routes and commanding access to ‘both seasonal military labour and the riches of a thriving pastoral economy, especially horses and camels’. However, Ajmer’s significance radiated well beyond its location and economic heft. In choosing to make his stand there, Salim must have recalled the legends of the fervour and joy surrounding his own birth, mediated by Shaikh Salim himself, and celebrated with joy and gratitude by Akbar. Ajmer, which for the entire duration of Salim’s boyhood, had been the sacred destination of Akbar’s yearly pilgrimages.

Having decided to revolt in the middle of the year 1600, with Akbar and the army far away in the Deccan, Salim made an unconvincing attempt to march upon the treasury at Agra. When he crossed the Yamuna and reached the outskirts of Agra, Hamida Banu, who was in Fatehpur Sikri, heard of her beloved grandson’s erratic and suspicious behaviour. Determined to confront him, and bring him to his senses, the old lady rode out of Fatehpur